The Moon Please

By Diana Son

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR: *September 11, 2001 – New York City*
ACTRESS: *New parents Jay and Ciel are struggling to navigate work, finances, and sleepless nights with a newborn.*
ACTOR: *Their everyday chaos and arguments could change everything. You see, Ciel's first day back at work will take her to the Twin Towers on 9/11.*
ACTRESS: *Should she stay home with the baby?*
TOGETHER: *The Moon Please by Diana Son*

CIEL: **(Pg 207-216)** *(JAY walks in as CIEL looks through a stack of papers)* I'm missing a page. I'm *(riffles through report)* The page with the pie chart. It should be right here.

JAY: What color is this tie?

CIEL: I can't go in there without that page. You know how Schaefer is, he's gotta have his visual! Dammit, I can't believe this is happening to me today. *(notices JAY 's tie)* Brown. It doesn't go.

JAY: This tie is brown? It's not blue?

CIEL: No. *(JAY stares at the tie, willing it to turn blue)* Wear your maroon tie . . . the one with the squiggly stripes. *(riffling again)*

JAY: Just print another copy, honey, it doesn't have to be /

CIEL: I can't print it out. The baby's been sleeping so lightly lately and our printer makes such a rack /

JAY: She's gotta get used to our noises. Remember what the doctor said? I mean, this is a one-bedroom apartment. We've all gotta share the space.

CIEL: I know that, but I just can't deal with her being awake when I leave and I have to leave in *(checks watch)* 10 minutes at the latest. Can you wait until Georgia gets here?

JAY: What time is she supposed to come?

CIEL: *(checks watch)* 20 minutes ago.

JAY: I can't be late to my interview. I mean, they're not gonna hire someone who can't

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even come to the interview on time. Maybe you should call her.

CIEL: What time's your interview?

JAY: Nine.

CIEL: What about my pie chart?

JAY: Print it at the office.

CIEL: I forgot to pack my pump. *(heading for the kitchen)* We're not meeting at the office. We're doing the pitch at a conference room.

JAY: *(leaving for the bedroom)* You better call Georgia. *(CIEL returns to the living room and picks up the phone)*

CIEL: Be quiet when you're in there, please. *(JAY in the bedroom, takes down a tie and freezes when he hears the baby) (as she dials)* It's just that it took me 45 minutes to get her down. *(into phone)* Hey! What are you still doing home? It's 8:20, you said you'd be here twe- *(CIEL listens. JAY peers into the baby's bassinet and watches her breathe as if it were possible the next breath won't come)* Georgia. . . It's going to take you half an hour just to get here. I have to be all the way downtown by nine *(drops the phone [still holding it] and covers her eyes. Puts it to her ear again. Meanwhile, JAY can't resist the temptation to touch the baby ever so slightly, to establish a connection without waking her)* I can't believe you. This is my first day back at work! How can you ***do*** this to me, Georgia? I'm the only one making any money, what are we gonna do if I get *fi- (JAY reenters with the new tie. Ciel doesn't pursue this line of thinking)* You are totally irresponsible. I can't. No, forget it, I don't even want you to come. *(slams down the phone. JAY waits for her to make the first move)* I can't believe her.

JAY: I guess that's what we get for not hiring a real babysitter.

CIEL: You don't think it's better for the baby that we have a friend, someone we know and trust, to stay with her? Instead of some stranger?

JAY: A stranger might be here right now. *(CIEL doesn't want to start this now. She heads back to the kitchen to get her pump)* So, is she coming? Over?

CIEL: No! I don't know!

JAY: Ciel, we're never gonna be able to move out of this one-bedroom apartment unless

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I get a job and start making some /

CIEL: *(turning around)* I wasn't volunteering you to stay home, Jay.

JAY: ***You're*** gonna stay home? *(long silence, heavy sigh)* *Fine*, I'll blow off my interview.

CIEL: That's not what I'm saying, Jay. I know how anxious you are to get back to work.

JAY: I think she's starting to notice me. Lately. You know what I mean? *(CIEL doesn't know the right response)* For the first couple of months, I was just some ***guy*** who was hanging around being mommy's helper. But lately I can tell that she, like, I don't know, maybe knows who I am.

CIEL: Are you saying you want to be a stay-at-home dad? Because that would be even better than /

JAY: I don't know. It's a big commitment. It depends what happens at this interview.

CIEL: *(heads for the phone)* I'll call Georgia back. I'll call Shaefer, tell him I'll be a few min-utes late/

JAY: No, you go. *(CIEL stops dialing)* It's more important that you be there on time. It's your first day back. If you're late, Shaefer's gonna leap to all kinds of conclusions, about how you're not committed to the job / *(CIEL stuffs the report in her bag and picks up her keys)*

CIEL: If I leave now, I can print my pie chart at the client's office.

JAY: What floor are they on?

CIEL: The 275th or something like . . . I have it *(fishes through her purse for her date book)*

JAY: They only go up to 110.

CIEL: When I was at NYU, they had these old-fashioned elevators in the main building that could fit like 30 people and you had to shout over everyone's heads what floor you wanted: 7, please; 11 please; 13. . . And somebody would inevitably say "The moon, please." Typical freshman humor . . . but sweet, really. Whenever I'm in the towers, I think about that. I want to say it. "The moon, please." *(finds her datebook)* 95th floor. *(slams the datebook shut and kisses JAY)* Thank you, honey. Good luck on your interview. I'll call you after lunch. *(opens the door)* I'll call Georgia right now!

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JAY: *(indicating the baby)* Sssh! *(CEIL waves good-bye and exits. JAY dials the phone)*

CIEL: *(walking back in)* I forgot the pump.

JAY: *(into phone, tentative)* Hi Kathy, this is Jay Coleman, I have a 9 A.M. interview and I'm going to be a few minutes late. Sorry for the inconvenience. Okay, thank you. Bye. *(CIEL with the pump on her shoulder waves at JAY as she puts her hand on the doorknob)*

CIEL: *(whispering)* Bye again.

JAY: You look happy.

CIEL: *(CIEL walks back to him)* What? *(on edge)* What did you say?

JAY: You look happy. You look psyched to be going to work.

CIEL: What do you mean by that? I look ***happy*** to be going to work? Are you saying you don't think I have conflicted feelings? *(steps closer to avoid yelling)* How dare you accuse me of /

JAY: ***Accuse?!***

CIEL: Our daughter's not even 3 months old yet! She's still half moosh and I have to leave her for ten hours a day! You think I ***want*** to go back to work? *(beat)* You don't have a job, Jay. How can I even fantasize about staying home with her when you're not bringing in any /

JAY: How am I supposed to make any money if I can't even go to a job interview on time.

CIEL: *(slams down her bag)* Go to your interview. Go. Go! I'd love to quit my job. I'll call Shaefer right now -- tell him to pitch to a client without me. *(JAY can't tell whether to take her seriously)* Go to your interview, Jay.

JAY: *(after a pause)* All right. *(slowly gathers his stuff)* Are you gonna call Georgia?

CIEL: Don't worry about it. Maybe I'll call her, maybe I'll stay with the baby myself. Maybe I'll get fired, maybe Shaefer will be completely sympathetic. Who knows?

JAY: *(tries to kiss her before he leaves)* I'll see you later.

(CIEL watches him leave. Exhales. Her mind races-what has she gotten herself into? Walks into the bedroom and looks at the baby. She picks her up gingerly, hoping not to wake her and rests her against her shoulder. Inhales her scent deeply. JAY comes back into the apartment. She eases the baby off her shoulder and lowers her back into the bassinet. Makes sure the baby doesn't wake then walks into the living room)

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CIEL: Jay...?

JAY: I'm sorry, you're right. It was totally insensitive of me to accuse you of not feeling ambivalent about going back to work. *(slight pause)* You have worked so hard to get to your position and you deserve to come back with a bang. Yes, you're a mother but you're also the *best* vice president they have. *(long pause. Takes off his tie and shoes)* How many ounces of milk do we have in the freezer? I think I saw at least 5 or 6 of those bags and those are each 8 ounces. That'll get us through the day. Do you know where the Bjorn is? It's such a beautiful day, I was thinking of taking the baby out to the park. Maybe even see if she likes the swing /

CIEL: You're forcing me to go to work.

JAY: *(now he's mad)* What!?

CIEL: You're, like, pushing me out the door. And you have the nerve to talk about what a great day you're going to have with the baby while I'm locked in my office!

JAY: Ciel, you should have seen your face ***light up*** when you were walking out the door knowing you were going to work all day.

CIEL: Jay, just because you're too scared or, or, or lazy /

JAY: You're worried that your new mommy friends are going to think you're a terrible mother just because you like to work. Face it, Ciel, you're a workaholic. You love it.

CIEL: *(rage causing volume)* How dare you tell me I love to work. I ***have*** to work /

JAY: *(simultaneously)* The status, the power /

CIEL: This is the third job interview you've blown off.

JAY: Even when I had a job you were working all the time. You didn't even want to take the full three months off! *(their voices rise)*

CIEL: That was ***before*** I had the baby /

JAY: Oh, so, what? You've had a personality transplant since you gave birth?

CIEL: You don't think giving birth is a transformative /

JAY: You've been working this whole time from home! You've been preparing this pitch for months!

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CIEL: It's my account!

JAY: *(simultaneously)* You couldn't stomach the idea of Shaefer giving Grace Chan this account.

CIEL: Grace Chan couldn't deliver this account if it was a pepperoni pizza. ***I*** did all the leg work, ***I*** developed the relationships, and ***I*** deserve the damn commission /

JAY: So, go! *(after a pause, CIEL grabs her bag and hooks it onto her shoulder)*

CIEL: *(calmly)* I am the youngest person in my position. I am the only woman, and I got where I am because my work is excellent. Just let me nail this account and . . . and then we'll / *(the baby starts to cry. They look at each other, then start for the room)*

JAY: I'll get her

CIEL: No, I'll get her. *(they stop)*

JAY: If you pick her up, she's going to freak out when you leave. *(cell phone rings)* That's your phone.

CIEL: What time is it?

JAY: 8:35. If you take a cab, you could be there before nine.

(CIEL looks at JAY then continues toward the baby's room. The cell phone continues ringing. She picks up the baby and nestles her into her chest. The baby wails)

CIEL: Okay, it's okay. Sshhhh . . . Thatta girl. Mama's here. *(exhales and looks up. There's so much to lose -- She rests her head against the baby's and looks at JAY)* Mama's gonna stay.

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AWARD HISTORY

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